India–China relations began to deteriorate. The Tibet revolt in 1959 and the grant of asylum to His Holiness the Dalai Lama in India, followed by a large number of Tibetan refugees, brought relations to a new low. The skirmishes on the India–China border hereafter took on a strategic dimension as a nervous China began to see them as efforts to undermine its rule over Tibet. It is interesting that India–China relations, the 1962 border war and the Tibet issue do not find mention in the Resolution, though there is a general reference to the People's Liberation Army (PLA) having 'bravely defended the security of the motherland'.

According to the 1981 Resolution, by January 1962 at an Enlarged Central Work Conference attended by 7,000 delegates, the Great Leap Forward was repudiated, there was 'criticism and self-criticism' of the Left errors, and cadres dismissed as 'right opportunists' were rehabilitated. It also mentioned that to deal with the crisis, it was President Liu Shaoqi, Premier Zhou Enlai, Vice Premiers Deng Xiaoping and Chen Yun who were 'put in charge' and that the situation improved. There is no mention here of Mao having any role to play. In fact, from other sources we know that he was pushed to the so-called 'second line' of leadership.

It was only to be expected that Mao would fight back to reassert his undisputed leadership, and in fact the counter-attack came later that year, when in the tenth plenary session of the Eighth Central Committee in September 1962 Mao Zedong once again 'absolutized the class struggle', reiterating his earlier stand that the principal contradiction in China currently was still that between the proletariat and the petty bourgeoisie. Despite this, the Resolution asserts that there was 'fairly smooth development' between 1962 and 1966.

We know from archives now available that this was the time that Mao began to strengthen his hold over the PLA, and that the directives relating to the India–China border situation were issued by him directly to the PLA command. The decision to launch military operations against India to 'liquidate the invading Indian Army' was reportedly taken in a Politbureau meeting in August 1962, where those opposed to this were denounced as 'right opportunists'.[6]